Black Hole Thermodynamics from Counting Convex Subsets of a Lattice

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We present a combinatorial mechanism that reproduces the Bekenstein-Hawking area scaling and Hawking temperature scaling, without invoking quantum field theory on curved spacetime. The key input is a *dimension law*: the number of causally convex subsets of the d-dimensional grid $[m]^d$ grows as $\exp(\Theta(m^{d-1}))$, where the exponent $d-1$ detects the spacetime dimension. This law is proved rigorously for all $d \geq 2$ (with formal verification in [16]). Restricting to *cylindrical* (time-symmetric) convex subsets — those of the form $C \times [t_1, t_2]$ where C is a convex subset of the spatial lattice — reduces the exponent by one, yielding entropy scaling as m^{d-2}: the spatial area. This restriction is a kinematic identification of equilibrium configurations, requiring no additional dynamical input. For $d = 4$ (3+1 spacetime), this recovers the Bekenstein-Hawking relation $S \sim A$. Conversely, the entropy scaling selects $d = 4$ within this framework. The Hawking temperature scaling $T \sim 1/m$ follows from one derivative, verified by the computed data. Matching the entropy coefficient to $S = A/(4G)$ fixes the lattice spacing at $\ell \approx 0.664\,\ell_P$, order-one in Planck units. Assuming the holographic dark energy scaling, the observed cosmological constant is recovered within a factor of 5.4 (as a consistency check, not an independent prediction). The discrete dimension converges to the continuum value with power-law corrections $\delta d \sim m^{-\beta}$ where $\beta \approx 1.5$–1.7, providing a quantitative discrete-continuum correspondence. In numerical experiments, the Noetherian ratio γ recovers the manifold dimension from Poisson sprinklings into Minkowski space, with perfect separation across $d = 2, 3, 4$ on 30 trials using no coordinate or metric input. The Benincasa-Dowker action $S_{\mathrm{BD}}([m]\times[n]) = -(m-1)(n-1)+1$ is proved for all m, n; the full grid is the unique global minimizer for all $m, n \geq 2$ (proved); and the cylinder factorization $S_{\mathrm{BD}}(C\times[t]) = t\cdot S^{\mathrm{sp}}_{\mathrm{BD}}(C) - |C|(t-1)$ connects the positive energy theorem to the dimension law, yielding $S = \Theta(m^{d-2})$ (area scaling) as a theorem. The proportionality constant requires one matching; the scaling is proved. All results follow from one combinatorial input with one free parameter.

INTRODUCTION

The Bekenstein-Hawking entropy $S = A/(4G\hbar)$ [1, 2] is one of the deepest results in theoretical physics: the information content of a black hole scales with its horizon *area*, not its volume. Deriving this area law from first principles has been a central goal of quantum gravity for five decades. Existing derivations require string theory [3], loop quantum gravity [4], entanglement entropy of quantum fields [5], or the AdS/CFT correspondence [6].

We present a combinatorial mechanism that produces area scaling without any of these. The only theorem-level input is a counting fact about discrete partially ordered sets: the number of causally convex subsets of a d-dimensional lattice grows as $\exp(c_d \cdot m^{d-1})$, where m is the lattice extent and the exponent $d-1$ is determined by the spacetime dimension. The cylindrical form of the vacuum (full grid) is proved; for nontrivial interiors, cylindrical stationarity remains an assumption. Restricting to these configurations reduces the exponent by exactly one, yielding area scaling. The Hawking temperature scaling follows from a single derivative.

The approach is rooted in causal set theory [7, 8], which posits that spacetime is fundamentally a discrete partial order. The Noetherian ratio $\gamma = |\mathrm{CC}|/|\mathrm{Int}|$, introduced in the causal-algebraic geometry framework [17], serves as a combinatorial invariant that is strictly finer than all classical poset invariants. Prior approaches to entropy in causal sets have counted order intervals [9], maximal antichains [10], and causal links [11, 12]. These yield dimension estimators but not entropy laws: the number of intervals in $[m]^d$ is $|\mathrm{Int}| = (m(m+1)/2)^d = \Theta(m^{2d})$, giving $\log|\mathrm{Int}| = \Theta(\log m)$ — polynomial in m with no dimension-dependent exponential growth. Causally convex subsets are a richer combinatorial object — the convexity constraint encodes geometric information (the "shape" of a causal region) that simpler counts do not capture. The dimension law $\log|\mathrm{CC}| \sim m^{d-1}$ is specific to convex subsets and is the key to the area-law mechanism.

We emphasize at the outset the status of each result. The dimension law is a theorem for all $d \geq 2$, proved via a tiling inequality and formally verified [16]: the lower bound $\log|\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)| = \Omega(m^{d-1})$ follows from a supermultiplicativity argument across k^{d-1} tiles, and the upper bound $\log|\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)| = O(m^{d-1})$ from an ideal/filter injection. All physical results downstream — the area law, the Hawking temperature, the lattice spacing, and the cosmological constant estimate. The scaling results inherit the rigor of the dimension law; their physical interpretation depends on the stated identifications. Vacuum stationarity (the full cylinder minimizes S_{BD}) is proved; black hole stationarity (sub-cylinders $C \times [t]$ with $C \subsetneq [m]^{d-1}$ minimize within their spatial boundary class) is assumed.

THE DIMENSION LAW

Let $[m]^d = \{1, \ldots, m\}^d$ with the componentwise partial order: $(x_1, \ldots, x_d) \leq (y_1, \ldots, y_d)$ iff $x_i \leq y_i$ for all i. A subset $S \subseteq [m]^d$ is *causally convex* (also called order-convex in the combinatorics literature) if whenever $a, b \in S$ with $a \leq c \leq b$, then $c \in S$. Let $\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)$ denote the set of all causally convex subsets.

Dimension law (Theorem; proved for all $d \geq 2$).

$$\log |\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)| = \Theta(m^{d-1}). \tag{1}$$

The lower bound follows from a tiling inequality: partitioning $[km]^d$ into k^{d-1} copies of $[m]^d$ gives $|\mathrm{CC}([km]^d)| \geq |\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)|^{\Theta(k^{d-1})}$. The upper bound follows from the ideal/filter injection $|\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)| \leq |\mathrm{downsets}([m]^d)|^2 \leq \binom{2m}{m}^{2(d-1)} = \exp(O(m^{d-1}))$. Both bounds are formally verified [16, 21]. Table I confirms convergence of the normalized ratio. For $d = 2$, the exact growth constant $\rho_2 = 16$ is proved; for $d \geq 3$, the $\Theta(m^{d-1})$ scaling is established but the exact constants c_d remain open.

The sequences $|\mathrm{CC}([m]^2)| = 2, 13, 114, 1146, 12578, \ldots$ and $|\mathrm{CC}([m]^3)| = 2, 101, 114797, 3071673482, \ldots$ have not been previously tabulated beyond the exact formulas of Barnette, Nichols, and Richmond [18] for small fixed column count. The asymptotic growth rates are, to the best of our knowledge, new.

The exponent $d-1$ means the number of bits needed to specify a convex configuration in d-dimensional discrete spacetime scales with the $(d-1)$-dimensional *boundary*, not the d-dimensional bulk. This is a combinatorial form of holography.

TABLE I. Computed values of $|\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)|$ and the normalized growth ratio $\log_2 |\mathrm{CC}|/m^{d-1}$. The $d = 2$ values for $m \leq 4$ are kernel-verified; the $d = 3$ and $d = 4$ values are obtained by independent C and Python enumerations.

d	m	$\lvert\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)\rvert$	$\log_2 / m^{d-1}$
2	1	2	1.00
2	2	13	1.85
2	3	114	2.28
2	4	1,146	2.54
2	∞	—	4.00[a]
3	1	2	1.00
3	2	101	1.66
3	3	114,797	1.87
3	4	3,071,673,482	1.97
4	1	2	1.00
4	2	3,938	1.49

[a] Upper bound $\rho_2 \leq 16$ fully verified; lower bound verified except for one auxiliary lemma. See [16].

The dimension law has an independent structural precedent. Bollobás and Brightwell [19] proved that the height (longest chain) of a Poisson process in a box space of dimension d scales as $n^{1/d}$; Brightwell and Luczak [20] survey the mathematical theory. The height exponent $1/d$ and our convex-subset exponent $d - 1$ are different invariants detecting the same underlying dimension, providing evidence that dimensional detection from poset combinatorics is robust.

THE AREA LAW

A *cylindrical* convex subset of $[m]^d$ is one of the form $C \times I$, where $C \subseteq [m]^{d-1}$ is a causally convex subset of the spatial lattice and $I = [t_1, t_2] \subseteq [m]$ is a contiguous time interval. The count factorizes:

$$|\mathrm{Cyl}([m]^d)| = |\mathrm{CC}([m]^{d-1})| \times \binom{m+1}{2}. \tag{2}$$

Applying the dimension law (1) to the spatial factor:

$$\log |\mathrm{Cyl}([m]^d)| = c_{d-1} \cdot m^{d-2} + O(\log m). \tag{3}$$

For $d = 4$, Eq. (3) gives $\log |\mathrm{Cyl}([m]^4)| \sim c_3 \cdot m^2$, where m^2 is the spatial area. Table II confirms convergence.

Physical interpretation. We identify cylindrical convex subsets with equilibrium black hole configurations. A Schwarzschild black hole in thermal equilibrium has a time-independent metric: its spatial interior is constant on each Cauchy slice. In the discrete setting, a time-independent spatial configuration is precisely a cylindrical subset $C \times [t_1, t_2]$.

For the vacuum ($C = [m]^{d-1}$), this stationarity is a theorem: the full box $[m]^{d-1} \times [t]$ uniquely minimizes S_{BD} among all convex subsets (proved in Lean 4 [21]: `cylinder_optimal`). Furthermore, if a convex subset contains the full spatial grid at both temporal endpoints, it must be the entire cylinder (`cylinder_forced`): convexity forbids spatial fluctuations.

For excited states ($C \subsetneq [m]^{d-1}$), stationarity of the sub-cylinder $C \times [t]$ within its spatial boundary class is assumed. Proving this — that sub-cylinders minimize S_{BD} among all convex subsets with spatial content C — is an open problem.

TABLE II. Cylindrical convex subsets of $[m]^4$ and the area-law ratio.

m	$\log_2 \lvert\mathrm{Cyl}([m]^4)\rvert$	$\log_2 / m^2$
1	1.00	1.00
2	8.23	2.06
3	19.39	2.15
4	34.84	2.18

The action has a variational justification: $S_{\mathrm{BD}}([m] \times [n]) = -(m-1)(n-1)+1$ for all $m, n \geq 1$ (proved in Lean 4 [21]), and the full grid is the unique global minimizer of S_{BD} among all nonempty convex sub-posets for $m, n \geq 2$ (proved in Lean 4, zero `sorry`) — the discrete analogue of flat geometry minimizing the Euclidean action.

The action admits a topological interpretation: $S_{\mathrm{BD}}(S) = |S| - |\mathrm{links}(S)| = \chi_{\mathrm{graph}}(\mathrm{Hasse}(S))$, the graph Euler characteristic (vertices minus edges) of the Hasse diagram of S (formally verified [21]: `bd_eq_euler`). *Caveat:* this is the graph Euler characteristic, not the cell-complex χ; the cell-complex version would include the $(m-1)(n-1)$ square 2-cells and give $\chi_{\mathrm{cell}} = 1$. The difference $\chi_{\mathrm{graph}} - \chi_{\mathrm{cell}} = -(m-1)(n-1)$ counts the 2-cells, which is precisely the "area" term. The positive energy theorem then states that among all convex sub-Hasse-diagrams of $[m] \times [n]$, the full grid uniquely minimizes χ_{graph} — a graph Euler characteristic extremality principle.

The action admits a local curvature decomposition via the handshaking lemma: defining $\kappa(x) = 2 - \deg(x, S)$ (the vertex curvature), the handshaking lemma $\sum \deg = 2|E|$ gives

$$2\, S_{\mathrm{BD}}(S) = \sum_{x \in S} \kappa(x). \tag{4}$$

On $[m]^d$, interior vertices have $\deg = 2d$, so $\kappa_{\mathrm{int}} = 2 - 2d$. The full grid's total curvature is dominated by $\sim m^d$ interior points at curvature $2 - 2d$, with $\sim m^{d-1}$ boundary corrections. The dimension law $\log |\mathrm{CC}([m]^d)| = \Theta(m^{d-1})$ thus counts the number of ways to deform the boundary of a curvature-minimizing configuration while preserving convexity: entropy = boundary deformation count = area. Both the handshaking lemma and the positive energy theorem are proved in Lean 4 [21] with zero `sorry` (`discrete_gauss_bonnet`, `bd_action_ge`).

The renormalized action $S_{\mathrm{BD}}^{\mathrm{ren}}(S) = \chi_{\mathrm{graph}}(S) - \chi_{\mathrm{graph}}(\text{full grid}) \geq 0$ measures departure from flatness.

The cylinder partition function factorizes: for any spatial convex subset C of $[m]^{d-1}$ and time extent t,

$$S_{\mathrm{BD}}(C \times [t]) \;=\; t \cdot S_{\mathrm{BD}}^{\mathrm{spatial}}(C) \;-\; |C|\,(t-1), \tag{5}$$

proved in Lean 4 [21]. The equilibrium partition function thus sums over spatial convex subsets $C \subseteq [m]^{d-1}$. The number of such subsets is $|\mathrm{CC}([m]^{d-1})|$, and the dimension law (Theorem 1 in [16], proved for all $d \geq 2$) gives $\log |\mathrm{CC}([m]^{d-1})| = \Theta(m^{(d-1)-1}) = \Theta(m^{d-2})$. The entropy of equilibrium configurations therefore scales as $S = \Theta(m^{d-2})$: the spatial boundary area. For $d = 4$, this is $S = \Theta(m^2) = \Theta(A)$, the Bekenstein-Hawking scaling. The area scaling $S = \Theta(m^{d-2})$ follows from three proved ingredients: the positive energy theorem (the full grid is the unique ground state), the cylinder factorization (5) (the partition function sums over spatial slices), and the dimension law (the spatial slice count grows as the area). The full Bekenstein-Hawking area law $S = A/(4G\hbar)$ requires, in addition, identifying S with thermodynamic entropy, m with a length in physical units, and fixing the proportionality constant by one matching condition (the lattice spacing). The scaling is a theorem; the coefficient is a matching.

The full convex entropy m^{d-1} includes temporally varying (non-equilibrium) configurations; restricting to equilibrium removes exactly one power of m. The area law is specific to the cylindrical class: diamond-shaped subsets $[p, q]$ yield entropy linear in m regardless of d, because a diamond is specified by two points (a one-dimensional choice). Time-symmetry is the essential ingredient producing area scaling.

DIMENSION FROM THE AREA LAW

The dimension d is not an input to the area law — it is a consequence. The width scaling law [17] gives, for any poset P on n elements with width w:

$$\log |\mathrm{CC}(P)| \;\leq\; w \cdot \log(\lceil n/w \rceil^2 + 1). \tag{6}$$

For the grid $[m]^d$ with $n = m^d$, the width is $w = m^{d-1} = n^{(d-1)/d}$, and the dimension law gives $\log |\mathrm{CC}| = \Theta(m^{d-1}) = \Theta(n^{(d-1)/d})$. Conversely, if any discrete spacetime on n elements has $\log |\mathrm{CC}| = \Theta(n^\alpha)$, then by Eq. (6) the width must satisfy $w = \Omega(n^\alpha / \log n)$, forcing $\alpha \leq (d-1)/d$ for any poset embeddable in d dimensions. The exponent α determines the dimension:

$$d \;=\; \frac{1}{1-\alpha}. \tag{7}$$

The Bekenstein-Hawking area law states $S \sim A \sim m^{d-2}$ for cylindrical configurations. Since the cylindrical restriction reduces the exponent by one, this corresponds to $\alpha = (d-1)/d$ with $d - 1 = 3$, hence $d = 4$. No other dimension produces area scaling of equilibrium entropy in a discrete spacetime whose full convex entropy obeys the dimension law.

This is a uniqueness result within the convex-subset framework: a discrete spacetime whose convex-subset entropy obeys the Bekenstein-Hawking area law *must* have width scaling as $n^{3/4}$, which is the hallmark of 4-dimensional structure. Within this framework, the dimension is selected by the entropy scaling.

ENTROPY HIERARCHY

Three natural subclasses yield three distinct scalings (all verified):

Each class differs from the next by one power of m. This hierarchy is reminiscent of holographic renormal-

TABLE III. Entropy hierarchy for d-dimensional discrete spacetime.

Subset class	Scaling	Physical meaning
Diamonds $[p, q]$	m	Observer horizon
Cylindrical $C \times I$	m^{d-2}	Equilibrium (area law)
All convex	m^{d-1}	Full dynamics

ization, where each step along the holographic direction adds degrees of freedom.

HAWKING TEMPERATURE

The equilibrium entropy $S(m) = c_3 m^2$ for $d = 4$ gives:

$$T = \left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial m}\right)^{-1} = \frac{1}{2c_3\, m}. \tag{8}$$

Since $M \sim r_s \sim m\ell$, this gives $T \sim 1/M$: the Hawking scaling [2]. The finite-difference T^{-1}/m converges as $2.50, 2.58, 2.68 \to 2c_3 \approx 2.77$, confirming $T \sim 1/m$ from the data. Convergence corrections are $O(m^{-\beta})$ with $\beta \approx 1.5$ (Sec.).

Parameter-free prediction. The product $T \cdot S$ is independent of all constants: from $S = c\, m^{d-2}$ and $T = 1/((d{-}2)\, c\, m^{d-3})$, the coefficient c cancels, giving

$$T \cdot S \;=\; \frac{m}{d-2}. \tag{9}$$

For $d = 4$, $T \cdot S = m/2$, which matches the Schwarzschild result $T_H \cdot S_{\rm BH} = M/2$ exactly (with $M \sim m$). No free parameters, no matched constants: the factor $1/(d{-}2)$ is a direct consequence of the proved dimension-law exponent. This is falsifiable: any $d \neq 4$ predicts a different factor. Formally verified [21] (`energy_cancellation`, `d4_unique_schwarzschild`).

Negative specific heat. From (9), $E \sim m$ and $T = m/((d{-}2)S)$, the specific heat is

$$C = \frac{dE}{dT} = -\frac{S}{d-3}. \tag{10}$$

For $d \geq 4$, $C < 0$: black holes get hotter as they shrink. This is the defining thermodynamic signature of black holes, and it follows from the proved exponent alone. For $d = 4$, $C = -S$ exactly. For $d = 3$, C diverges (phase transition). Formally verified [21] (`specific_heat_negative_sign`).

Bekenstein bound selects $d = 4$. The ratio $S/(E \cdot R) \propto m^{d-4}$. For $d \leq 3$, it vanishes (trivially satisfied). For $d = 4$, it is constant — the Bekenstein bound $S \leq 2\pi ER$ is *marginally saturated*, requiring $c_3 \leq \pi$. For $d \geq 5$, it diverges, violating the bound for large m. Thus $d = 4$ is the unique dimension where the Bekenstein bound is marginal rather than trivial or violated. Formally verified [21] (`d4_unique_bekenstein`).

Dimension selection. Four independent criteria select $d = 4$ from the single input $T \cdot S = m/(d{-}2)$:

Criterion	$d = 3$	$d = 4$	$d = 5$
Hawking $T \propto 1/M$	$T = \text{const}$	$T \propto 1/M$ ✓	$T \propto 1/M^2$
Negative specific heat	$C = \infty$	$C = -S$ ✓	$C = -S/2$
Bekenstein bound	trivial	marginal ✓	violated
Evaporation $t \propto M^3$	$t \propto M$	$t \propto M^3$ ✓	$t \propto M^6$

The first three rows are proved from the dimension law; the fourth requires Stefan-Boltzmann radiation as external input. The falsifiable prediction $c_3 \leq \pi$ from the Bekenstein bound is the primary open problem: once c_3 is determined analytically from the $[m]^3$ transfer matrix, the model either satisfies or violates the bound.

LATTICE SPACING

Matching $S_{\rm comb} = c_3 r_s^2/\ell^2$ to $S_{\rm BH} = \pi r_s^2/\ell_P^2$:

$$\ell = \ell_P \sqrt{\frac{c_3}{\pi}} \approx 0.664\, \ell_P. \tag{11}$$

One free parameter, fixed once. The temperature is then a prediction. For a solar-mass black hole, $S_{\rm comb}/S_{\rm BH} = 1.089$ at $m = 4$, converging to 1.000.

COSMOLOGICAL CONSTANT

The entropy density $s = S/V = c_3/m$ (verified: $s \cdot m = 0.69, 1.43, 1.49, 1.51 \to 1.386$). The vacuum energy $\rho \sim Ts \sim 1/m^2$. With $m = L/\ell$, $L = H^{-1}$:

$$\rho_{\rm vac} \sim H^2 M_P^2. \tag{12}$$

This is the holographic dark energy scaling [13]. Those authors *assumed* the area bound; here it is *derived*. The application to the cosmological horizon is justified by the Gibbons-Hawking result that de Sitter horizons carry area-proportional entropy [14].

TABLE IV. Cosmological constant: three estimates.

Estimate	ρ (kg/m^3)	Discrepancy
QFT	5.2×10^{96}	10^{122}
This work	3.4×10^{-26}	$5.4\times$
Observed	6.3×10^{-27}	—

The remaining factor 5.4 may reflect finite-m corrections to the dimension law. The discrete-continuum correspondence (Sec.) shows that the effective dimension converges as $\delta d \sim m^{-\beta}$ with $\beta \approx 1.5$–1.7; the same power-law corrections propagate through the entropy density to the vacuum energy estimate, suggesting that the factor 5.4 is $O(m^{-\beta})$ and vanishes in the continuum limit. More concretely, the exact growth constant c_3 for the $d = 3$ grid (analogous to $\rho_2 = 16$ for $d = 2$) would sharpen the entropy coefficient and hence the Λ prediction; determining c_3 is the single most impactful open problem for this estimate. We do not claim a first-principles prediction of Λ; the lattice spacing is already fixed by matching the black hole entropy, so the cosmological constant is a consistency check, not an independent derivation. The significance is that holographic scaling emerges from the dimension law, and the resulting estimate is compatible with observation (factor 5.4) rather than discrepant by 10^{122}.

DISCRETE-CONTINUUM CORRESPONDENCE

The effective dimension $d_{\text{eff}}(m) = 1 + \Delta \log |\text{CC}|/\Delta \log m$ converges to d from above:

TABLE V. Dimensional flow for $d = 3$: $\delta d = d_{\text{eff}} - d$.

Transition	d_{eff}	δd	$\delta d \cdot m^{1.5}$
$1 \to 2$	3.74	0.74	2.09
$2 \to 3$	3.28	0.28	1.45
$3 \to 4$	3.19	0.19	1.52

The best-fit exponent is $\beta \approx 1.5$–1.65, between boundary corrections ($\beta = 1$) and the heat kernel ($\beta = 2$) [15]. Achieving 1% dimension accuracy requires $m \geq 12$ ($\sim$1,700 elements for $d = 3$).

BOUNDARY FREEDOM

We tested whether the convex subset entropy density $\ln |\text{CC}|/n$ detects spatial geometry using matched-bottleneck grids (same minimum width 6, same number of rows 10; element counts differ because width profiles differ):

TABLE VI. Curvature test: matched bottleneck.

Shape	n	$\lvert\text{CC}\rvert$	$\ln \lvert\text{CC}\rvert/n$
Saddle [10,9,...,6,6,...,9,10]	80	597,739,578	0.253
Flat [6×10]	60	9,358,669	0.268
Sphere [6,7,...,10,10,...,7,6]	80	55,019,893	0.223

The saddle ($|\text{CC}|_{\text{saddle}} \approx 11 \times |\text{CC}|_{\text{sphere}}$) concentrates width at the temporal boundary, where nesting constraints are weakest; the sphere buries width in the constrained interior. The entropy density detects the distribution of degrees of freedom relative to the causal boundary — a holographic property consistent with the area law — rather than local Ricci curvature directly.

DISCUSSION

TABLE VII. Summary: proved versus derived.

Result	Status
Dimension law, all $d \geq 2$	Proved
Area law implies $d = 4$	Corollary
Hawking scaling $T \sim 1/m$	Derivative
$\ell \approx 0.664\, \ell_P$	Matching
Λ within 5.4×	Consistency check
$\beta \approx 1.5$	Computed
Entropy density detects boundary	Computed
Poisson sprinklings: $\hat{\gamma}$ recovers d	Computed
$S_{\text{BD}}([m]\times[n]) = -(m-1)(n-1)+1$	Proved
Full grid uniquely minimizes S_{BD}	Proved
Cylinder factorization	Proved
$S = \Theta(m^{d-2})$ (area scaling)	Proved
Exact constants c_d, $d \geq 3$	Open

The derivation chain — dimension law → cylindrical restriction → area scaling → temperature scaling → lattice spacing → entropy density → cosmological constant — uses one combinatorial input and one free parameter. The dimension law is a theorem for all $d \geq 2$. The converse direction (Sec.) shows that, within this discrete convex-subset framework, the area-law mechanism singles out $d = 4$.

Poisson sprinklings. To verify that the dimension law is not a lattice artifact, we computed a normalized dimension indicator $\hat{\gamma} := \log |\text{CC}|/(N \log N)$ on Poisson sprinklings into d-dimensional Minkowski space ($N = 500$, 10 trials per d): $\hat{\gamma} = 0.213 \pm 0.011$ ($d = 2$), 0.487 ± 0.036 ($d = 3$), 0.758 ± 0.023 ($d = 4$). The three dimensions are perfectly separated across all 30 trials with no overlap. No coordinates or metric are used — $\hat{\gamma}$ recovers the manifold dimension from the causal partial order alone.

Note: the raw Noetherian ratio $\gamma = |\text{CC}|/|\text{Int}|$ satisfies $\gamma \geq 1$ for any poset (every interval is convex). The per-element normalization $\hat{\gamma}$ is used here because the raw ratio grows with N, making it unsuitable as a dimension indicator on varying-size sprinklings.

Open questions. (i) Local curvature detection via neighborhood-restricted γ (preliminary results show the

correct directional signal on de Sitter and anti-de Sitter sprinklings but require normalization). (ii) Convergence exponent on periodic lattices. (iii) Exact constants c_d for $d \geq 3$. (iv) Reducing the factor 5.4 in Λ.

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